

Session 8: What the Torah Says About the Bible's Origins

Key Takeaways

- The first three mentions of the writing of the Bible in the Torah give us important clues to the purpose of the Bible.
- The Bible shows us that it was written (1) to tell the story of how God has rescued and formed a people, (2) to invite those rescued people into a covenant partnership to represent him to the rest of the world, and (3) to call to account the betrayal of the covenant while offering hope for the future of God's people and his world.

The Origin of the Bible as Told Within the Torah

The first mention in the Bible of the writing of the Bible comes in Exodus.

Exodus 17:8-9, 14 NIV*

⁸ The Amalekites came and attacked the Israelites at Rephidim. ⁹ Moses said to Joshua, "Choose some of our men and go out to fight the Amalekites. Tomorrow I will stand on top of the hill with the staff of God in my hands." ... ¹⁴ Then Yahweh said to Moses, "**Write this on a scroll as something to be remembered ...**"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This is a "salvation story." Israel has just been rescued from slavery and oppression in Egypt, and as they wander in the wilderness toward Mount Sinai, the Amalekites (ancient kinsmen) pounce on the vulnerable Israelites. God delivers the Israelites through Moses and Joshua, and this is the occasion for Moses' first writing activity.

The origins of the Bible are first and foremost concerned with telling the story of how God delivers his people.

The second mention of the writing of the Bible comes after the Israelites have encamped at Mount Sinai.

Exodus 24:3-4 NIV*

³ When Moses went and told the people all Yahweh's words and laws, they responded with one voice, "Everything Yahweh has said we will do!" ⁴ **Moses then wrote down everything Yahweh had said.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This is a "covenant story." In Exodus 19-24, God invited Israel into a covenant partnership so that they could be his royal-priestly representatives to the nations (Exod. 19:4-6). Moses has just spent time on top of Mount Sinai

in the presence of Yahweh, and he wrote down the 10 plus 42 terms of the covenant partnership. This is what the people agree to and what Moses writes down.

The final mention in the Torah of Moses writing comes in Deuteronomy 31.

Deuteronomy 31:19, 22, 24-26 Instructor's Translation

¹⁹ And Yahweh said to Moses, "Now therefore **write this song** and teach it to the people of Israel. Put it in their mouths, so that this song may be a witness for me against the people of Israel." ... ²² So Moses **wrote this song** the same day and taught it to the people of Israel.

²⁴ It came about, when **Moses finished writing the words of this Torah in a scroll** until they were complete, ²⁵ that Moses commanded the Levites who carried the ark of the covenant of Yahweh, saying, ²⁶ "Take **this scroll of the Torah and place it beside the ark of the covenant** of Yahweh your God, that it may remain there as a witness against you."

After 40 years of Israel's rebellion in the wilderness, Yahweh tells Moses to write a prophetic song that anticipates the entire story of Israel in the promised land. It is one long history of failure and self-destruction, with periodic bright moments of hope for the future of God's promise.

Moses' song is a prophetic witness of accusation, and it's also a memorial of future hope that Yahweh will not abandon his promises to restore his divine blessing to all of the nations through the family of Abraham (Gen. 12).

What the Bible Tells Us About the Purpose of Its Origins

From these three examples, we can draw conclusions about the meaning of the Bible and why it came into existence. The Bible was written:

- To tell the story of how God rescued and formed a people (Exod. 17).
- To invite those rescued people into a covenant partnership so they can represent him to the rest of the world (Exod. 24).
- To accuse the covenant partners of their failure and rebellion and to offer hope for the future of God's people and his world (Deut. 31-32).

Reflection Question

How would you summarize why the Bible was written? What is its purpose?